

KOS Starter Kit

Quick Installation Guide

Install a private, Markdown-first Knowledge OS; open it in Obsidian; and verify that Codex or Claude Code can use it.

RECOMMENDED PATH

Dry run first. Install from a validated answer file. Use interactive agent mode when you want help making the setup decisions.

TIME

10-15 minutes

OUTPUT

A portable folder of Markdown files with agent routing, project scaffolds, privacy rules, validation, and optional Git initialization.

What this guide covers

- Choose the right installation path.
- Generate the workspace without silently overwriting files.
- Open the result as an Obsidian vault.
- Verify agent routing, validation, privacy, and Git state.

Scope boundary

This guide covers installation and verification only. Workflow automation, synchronization, advanced Obsidian plugins, and KOS Power-Ups belong in separate guides.

Requirements and install paths

Run all commands from the starter-kit root - the folder containing README.md, initialize.ps1, and install.ps1.

Requirement	Windows	macOS / Linux
Shell	PowerShell 7+ recommended; Windows PowerShell 5.1 supported	Bash 4+
Runtime	Included PowerShell installer	Python 3
AI agent	Codex CLI or Claude Code - optional for direct installation	Codex CLI or Claude Code - optional for direct installation
Workspace tools	Obsidian, VS Code, Git - optional	Obsidian, VS Code, Git - optional

Choose one path

1. Interactive agent mode

Best for a first installation. Codex or Claude reads the installer contract and collects only answers that do not have safe defaults.

2. Answer-file mode - recommended for repeatability

Copy the example JSON, edit it, dry-run the exact configuration, then execute the installation. This is the strongest option for teams and repeatable environments.

Path safety

Use a new or empty target. A non-empty target requires migration mode. Filesystem roots, your home/profile directory, starter-kit ancestors, and link or reparse-point targets are rejected.

Install with Codex or Claude

Use this path when you want the agent to guide configuration decisions. The initializer passes the canonical KOS-INSTALLER.md contract to the selected agent.

Windows

```
.\initialize.ps1 -Agent codex  
.\initialize.ps1 -Agent claude
```

macOS or Linux

```
chmod +x initialize.sh install.sh scripts/*.sh  
./initialize.sh --agent codex  
./initialize.sh --agent claude
```

What happens next

1

Collect configuration

The agent asks for required identity, system, tool, privacy, rhythm, and installation settings that lack safe defaults.

2

Review the proposed target

Confirm the resolved target directory, installation mode, selected modules, and optional Git behavior.

3

Dry run

Review the proposed manifest before any workspace files are generated.

4

Generate

The installer creates the selected numbered domains, root contracts, system policies, state, and reports.

5

Verify

Review validation and privacy results before using the workspace.

Do not bypass the dry run

The dry run is the cheapest place to catch a wrong target path, an oversized module selection, or an unsafe privacy default.

Answer-file installation

Use answer-file mode when you need an auditable, repeatable configuration. Start from the synthetic example and replace its values.

1. Create your answer file

```
Copy-Item .\installer\answers.example.json .\installer\answers.json
# Edit installer/answers.json before continuing
```

Section	Decide
user	Preferred name, role, timezone, locale, communication style
system	Workspace name, short name, root folder, description
privacy	Default AI access and restricted folders
rhythm	Daily, weekly, memory, handoff, Git, and project checks
installation	Mode, exact target, samples, Git, scripts, overwrite, backup

2. Dry run, then install

```
.\install.ps1 -Answers .\installer\answers.json -DryRun
.\install.ps1 -Answers .\installer\answers.json
```

macOS or Linux

```
./install.sh --answers ./installer/answers.json --dry-run
./install.sh --answers ./installer/answers.json
```

Existing workspace?

Use -Migration on Windows or --migration on macOS/Linux. Existing files are preserved; differing intended content becomes a .new.md or .new proposal unless overwrite is explicitly enabled.

Confirm the generated workspace

A Standard installation includes all numbered domains. Lean or custom modes intentionally generate less.

```
My Knowledge OS/  
|-- 00 - System/      policies, config, installation, reports  
|-- 01 - Business/    clients, operations, products, strategy  
|-- 02 - Projects/     active, incubating, on-hold, completed  
|-- 03 - Personal/    restricted personal domains  
|-- 04 - Hobbies/  
|-- 05 - Knowledge/   research and reusable knowledge  
|-- 06 - Inbox/       imports and unprocessed notes  
|-- 07 - Daily/       daily notes and reviews  
|-- 08 - Templates/  
|-- 09 - Attachments/ restricted by default in the example  
|-- 99 - Archive/  
|-- AGENTS.md         canonical agent router  
|-- CLAUDE.md / CODEX.md thin adapters  
|-- memory.md / handoff.md  
`-- ARCHITECTURE.md and context policies
```

Open in Obsidian

1

Open folder as vault

In Obsidian, choose Open folder as vault and select the generated Knowledge OS root.

2

Check navigation

Confirm the numbered folders and root Markdown files appear. KOS remains a normal folder of files even without plugins.

3

Keep plugins minimal

Enable only the features you actually need. Do not turn installation into a plugin migration project.

Privacy default

Generated Knowledge OS repositories are private by default. Do not connect one to a public remote without a separate content review.

Test agent routing and validation

Run each agent from the generated Knowledge OS root. Start with read-only prompts so you can confirm routing before the agent edits anything.

Claude Code

```
claude
Read the KOS instructions and summarize the workspace structure.
Do not modify any files.
```

- Expected: Claude finds CLAUDE.md, follows the canonical router, and reports only existing folders/files.

Codex

```
codex
Read AGENTS.md and inspect this KOS workspace.
Identify active projects, memory, handoff, and archive locations.
Do not make changes.
```

- Expected: Codex follows AGENTS.md and identifies the correct active-project and lifecycle files.

Manual validation from the starter-kit root

```
.\scripts\validate-installation.ps1 -InstallationRoot "D:\KOS\My Knowledge OS"
.\scripts\privacy-scan.ps1 -Root "D:\KOS\My Knowledge OS"
```

macOS or Linux

```
./scripts/validate-installation.sh '/path/to/My Knowledge OS'
./scripts/privacy-scan.sh '/path/to/My Knowledge OS'
```

Pass criteria

Required files and folders exist; JSON parses; no template tokens remain; adapters stay thin; external automations remain Not configured; privacy has no blocking findings; no Git remote or push was configured.

Final checklist and recovery

[] Dry-run manifest reviewed before generation	[] Exact target directory confirmed
[] Generated root opened successfully in Obsidian	[] AGENTS.md, CLAUDE.md, and CODEX.md present
[] memory.md and handoff.md present	[] Installation validation reports PASS
[] Privacy scan has no blocking findings	[] Codex or Claude completes the read-only routing test
[] Git remote is absent unless you configured one later	[] Any future remote will be private and reviewed

Troubleshooting

Exit 2	Invalid input, unsafe path, missing requirement, or validation failure.
Exit 3	Unexpected script failure. Inspect the initializer log and installation state.
Interrupted	Resume with -Resume or --resume; do not assume a partial phase completed.
Conflict	Review the generated .new.md or .new proposal before merging.

Exact next action

Create one small project under 02 - Projects/Active, then use it to learn the memory and handoff workflow. Keep installation complete before adding automation, synchronization, or Power-Ups.

Source basis: repository README.md, INSTALL.md, INITIALIZE.md, KOS-INSTALLER.md, installer schema/manifest, and validation scripts. Prepared 5 August 2026.